MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 1 — Unit 3: Major Classifications of Shakespearean Plays

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Genres help us recognise a play’s patterns, while social discourses help us ask what its conflicts mean.

Start with a picture

A bookshop has shelves labelled mystery, comedy, and history. A single book may belong on more than one shelf. Shakespeare’s genre labels work like these signs: helpful guides, not locked boxes.

1. Tragedy

Tragedies involve grave conflict, suffering, and loss. Hamlet and Macbeth give obvious examples, but their paths to catastrophe differ. “A great man with one fatal flaw” is too narrow a definition. Choices, institutions, mistakes, and chance can all matter.

Pity and **fear** describe important responses associated with tragedy. Explain why an outcome matters instead of identifying tragedy only by a body count.

2. Comedy

Comedies often use disguise, misrecognition, witty dialogue, festive settings, and marriages or reunions. Twelfth Night resolves the twin confusion, but Malvolio’s treatment leaves discomfort. An ending can establish a new arrangement without making every character happy.

3. History and Roman plays

The English histories explore kingship, succession, national identity, and legitimacy. Richard II, the Henry IV plays, and Richard III offer different treatments. They are dramatic interpretations of history, not neutral transcripts.

“Roman plays” is a grouping by setting and sources. Julius Caesar, Antony and Cleopatra, and Coriolanus are also tragedies. These two labels can apply at different levels.

4. Romance

Later plays often grouped as romances combine separation, danger, wonder, recognition, forgiveness, and reunion. The Tempest and The Winter’s Tale are major examples. Romance here does not simply mean a love story, and the grouping was developed by later criticism.

5. Problem plays

Measure for Measure and All’s Well That Ends Well are often called problem plays because their moral situations and resolutions resist easy satisfaction. The category is debated. An uneasy ending is a reason to examine a classification rather than repeat it mechanically.

6. Shakespeare and English

His writing exploits word formation, flexible grammar, multiple registers, punning, and figurative expression. Many familiar expressions have early recorded appearances in the plays. “First surviving record” does not prove that one writer invented a word nobody had previously spoken.

7. Social discourses: the arguments a society lives with

Humanism asks about education and human capacities. **Feudalism** concerns hierarchies of land, obligation, and service. **Patriarchy** gives men institutional authority over women. **Imperialism** concerns the expansion and domination of power across peoples and territories.

Questions of same-sex desire and gendered identity also appear. Modern categories such as “homosexual” do not map neatly onto every early modern relationship. Analyse the language and historical setting without denying the presence of desire or assuming a proven biography.

A simple way to apply the ideas

For The Tempest, begin with romance and reconciliation. Then ask who controls the island, whose labour makes events possible, and what freedom means for different figures. Genre and criticism now work together.

Quick check

1. Can a Roman play also be a tragedy? **Yes; setting and genre are different classifications.**
2. Does a comic ending guarantee universal happiness? **No.**
3. Does a dictionary’s first example prove invention? **No; earlier uses may not survive.**

Build an exam answer

1. Define genre and explain its usefulness.
2. Distinguish setting labels from formal patterns.
3. Analyse one apparently comic or romantic resolution.

4. Introduce a social question the label cannot settle.
5. Conclude that classification should lead to close reading.

Common mistake to avoid

Do not treat all plays as perfectly fitted to exclusive categories or claim that every printed word first attested in Shakespeare was invented by him.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

Why are genre classifications useful but insufficient when reading Shakespeare?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Genre gives a reader an initial set of expectations. Comedy often directs confusion towards reunion, while tragedy makes irreversible loss central. History raises questions about political legitimacy; romance introduces wonder and recovery. These patterns help explain dramatic movement, but they do not prescribe the entire meaning of a play. Shakespeare’s use of mixed tones and unresolved pressures makes any classification provisional.

Twelfth Night illustrates the problem clearly. Its disguise plot and final recognition support a comic structure. Nevertheless, the mistreatment of Malvolio and the uncertain futures of some figures complicate the pleasure of closure. The reader should therefore distinguish the resolution of the principal plot from the reconciliation of every social or emotional difficulty.

The Tempest offers a related case. Its movement towards forgiveness can be read within romance, but that movement takes place through Prospero’s control of the island and the service of Ariel and Caliban. Questions of labour, coercion, and possession cannot be answered simply by naming the genre. A postcolonial or political reading brings these tensions into view without requiring the claim that genre has become irrelevant.

A mature account uses classification as an opening, then tests it through evidence. The same method applies to language and social discourse: claims about humanism, patriarchy, or imperialism need specific speeches, scenes, and relationships. Critical vocabulary should sharpen observation rather than replace it. The value of a label lies in the questions it makes possible.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Compare and contrast Shakespeare’s tragedies and comedies with examples.

2. Discuss the significance of Shakespeare’s contribution to the English language.
3. Analyse how Shakespeare’s plays engage with humanism and social hierarchy.
4. Examine the role of patriarchy and gender in select Shakespearean plays.
5. Evaluate the representation of imperialism and cultural conflict in Shakespeare’s works.